

Born into a middle-class family in Delhi, Sanjay Gupta grew up in a joint family setup. Besides his three sisters, he had many cousins to play with and a wealth of elders to seek advice from. Gupta remembers being the naughtiest child in the family, always the last to stop celebrating a festival. His parents 'literally' had to scold him to make sure he stopped bursting crackers on Diwali or playing with colours on Holi.

"I would be the first child in the family to start bursting crackers and the last one to stop. I don't know why, but I continue to love Indian festivals and the unity they bring out," he says. Another vivid memory from his school days is his mother being called up by teachers to inform her that her son was always featured in the list of the top five naughtiest kids!

Simultaneously, Gupta was also among the top five performing students in academics. He completed his schooling in two different government schools in Delhi. "My grandfather passed away when my father was young. I have heard a lot of stories about how my father built everything from scratch for the family. He's my role model," Gupta says with eyes full of pride.

IIT kya hota hai? (What's IIT?)

Education was always important, but Gupta's focus on academics increased significantly when he entered the sixth grade. After that, the kid who used to be in the top five students list regularly topped his classes. Even though he scored above 90% in the tenth Boards exam, he had no idea what he wanted to do in life!

"One day, one of my father's close friends visited us for breakfast. His son had just joined IIT Delhi. Over tea, he was talking to me and inquiring about my future plans



Sanjay Gupta with family

when he mentioned the word IIT. I asked my father and him, 'IIT Kya Hota Hai' (What is IIT?). I had no idea what IIT stood for," he laughs.

Within the next 15 minutes, Gupta, Gupta's father, and that friend were sitting in the latter's newly bought Maruti 800, on their way to one of the prominent IIT coaching and preparation centres in Delhi. After ten minutes of discussions at the centre, Gupta was asked to take a mock entrance exam. The results were out the same day, and the centre was ready to coach him for IIT preparation. But there was one catch! The monthly fee for the centre was ₹2,500, an amount equivalent to what his father's government job was paying him every month!

"My Papa did not even think about what would happen and said yes, please admit him. That sacrifice he made that day is something I always have in my mind before starting work every day," his eyes fill up with tears.

It was the start of a bigger chal-

lenge for him as he had a limited command on English language. The majority of his peers at the centre came from wealthy families, and this was also the first time he would be coming out of his comfort zone. His peers would arrive at the centre in swanky cars, indulging in burgers and all kinds of fast food for lunch, while Gupta would have to travel by bus and eat homemade food. Did this disturb him?

"Of course it did! What the world expects from you at that age is not important, but what you expect from the world is! I couldn't make any friends there. Sometimes the bus didn't show up, and I faced a lot of other challenges," he explains.

Back in school, Gupta was becoming a champion in yoga. His school sent him to inter-school yoga championships, and he was also asked to conduct yoga classes in the school. He believes that yoga helped him remain calm and seek solutions during his IIT preparation days. As luck would have it, he cleared